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Pig Butchering Scam: How a "Part-Time Job" Became a ₹3 Lakh Crypto Investment Trap



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> A technical breakdown and awareness post about Pig Butchering and Investment Scams. In this post, I walk through a real scam incident, from the initial anonymous WhatsApp message to the final fake trading app investment trap.

Recently I came across a pig-butchering scam, where the victim lost about ₹3 lakh rupees. My goal with this post is to create awareness to recognize these scams before falling for it. This post covers the following sections

1. Introduction
2. Scam Modus Operandi
3. OpenSource Intelligence (OSINT) analysis
4. Suspicious scam website dynamic analysis
5. Suspicious scam website source code analysis
6. Threat Hunting - Fingerprinting the operator with a Canarytoken
7. Conclusion

1. Introduction

In a 'Pig Butchering' scam (derived from the Chinese term sha zhu pan), the scammer 'fattens the victim' by building trust and showing fake profits over days or weeks, and then 'slaughters' them by taking everything at once.

A romance, friendship, or job opportunity lure leads to a fake investment app where the balance only looks like it's growing; the numbers are fabricated and the trades are completely manipulated. The moment the victim tries to withdraw, they're blocked and told to pay tax/additional fees/processing fees. It's organized cyber-crime that targets people around the world.

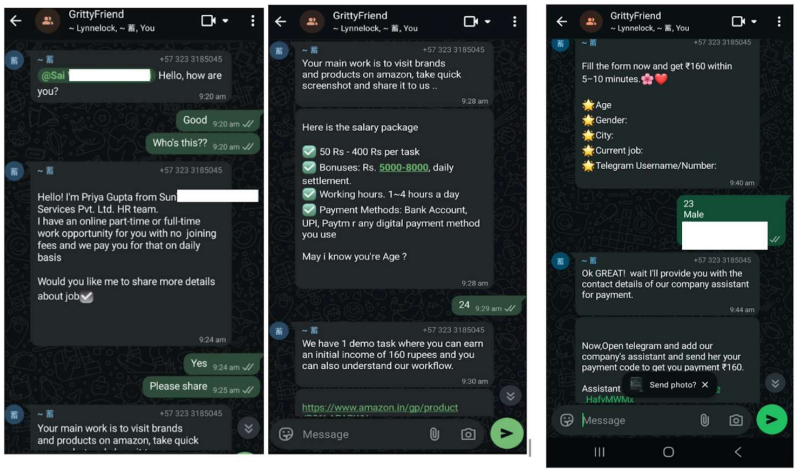
How big are these scams?

- According to **FBI IC3 Annual Report 2025**, Cryptocurrency investment fraud was the single largest source of financial losses for Americans in 2025, accounting for **$7.2 billion** in reported losses.
- In India, there were ~28.15 lakh cybercrime complaints in 2025 (MHA data, **ThePrint**). Total losses were at least ₹22,495 crore in 2025. Investment fraud accounted for ~76% of all money lost and ~35% of cases.

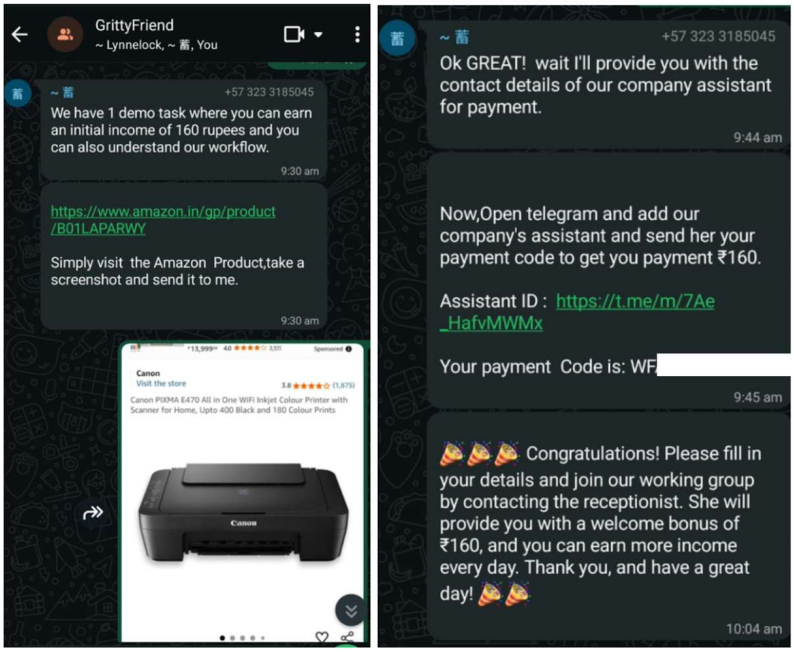
2. Scam Modus Operandi

Phase 1: The Hook & Initial Bait

The victim was contacted and added to WhatsApp group. This is classic WhatsApp task scam where scammer used a Colombia number (+57), impersonating an Indian HR recruiter offering payouts for viewing Amazon links to build trust before pivoting to Telegram.



Phase 1: Fake HR pitch, and a bait payouts

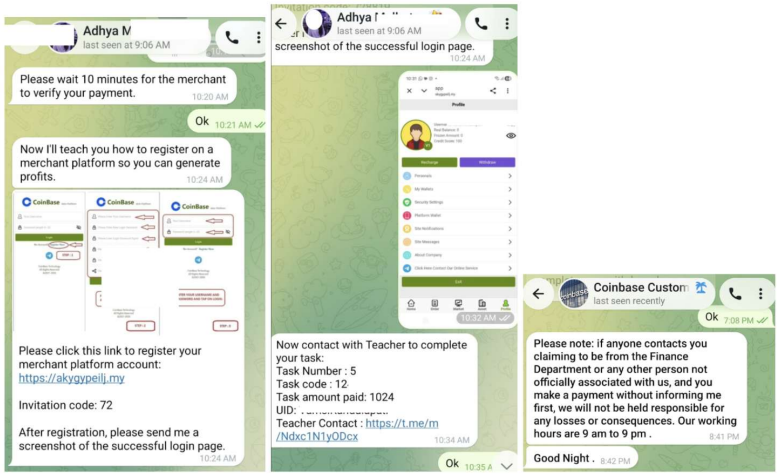


Phase 1 micro-payouts to build trust before shifting victims to telegram handles

- **[Red Flag 1]** Geographic Mismatch, a sender with a foreign country code (+57) claiming to represent an Indian corporate team.
- **[Red Flag 2]** Bait Payouts, Unrealistic pay structures (₹50–₹400/task) and demo earnings used to lure victims into larger deposit traps.
- **[Red Flag 3]** Platform Jumping, Requests to move communication and payment setup from WhatsApp to anonymous Telegram handles.

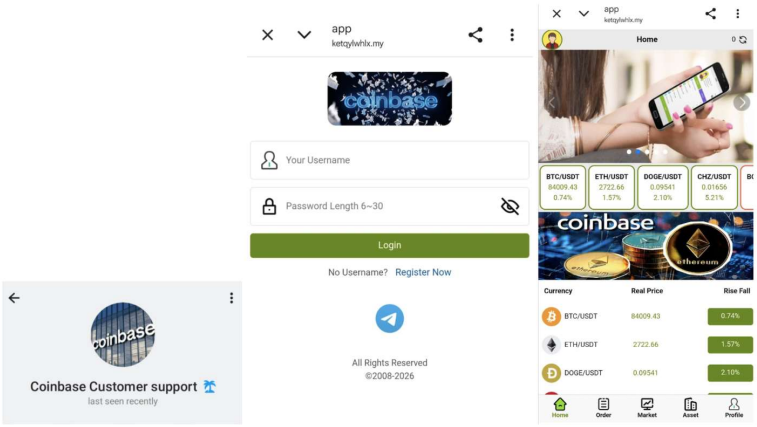
Phase 2: Routing to Telegram & Identity Assignment

- The second phase of the task scam, where scammers suggested the victim to Telegram to register on a fraudulent merchant platform link(**https[:]//akygypeilj[.]my**) spoofing Coinbase, requiring them to assign tasks, submit login screenshots, and deal with a fake teacher (t[.]me/m/Ndxc1N1y0Dcx) alongside a bogus Coinbase customer support account.



Phase 2 shifts victims to fake crypto investment websites

- **[Red Flag 4]** The use of malicious phishing domains, impersonating legitimate exchanges (Coinbase), PII data collection(AADHAR number, SSN number), mandatory screenshot verification of account logins, structured task codes requiring financial commitment, and disclaimer warnings from scammers warning victims not to contact external finance teams to isolate them.

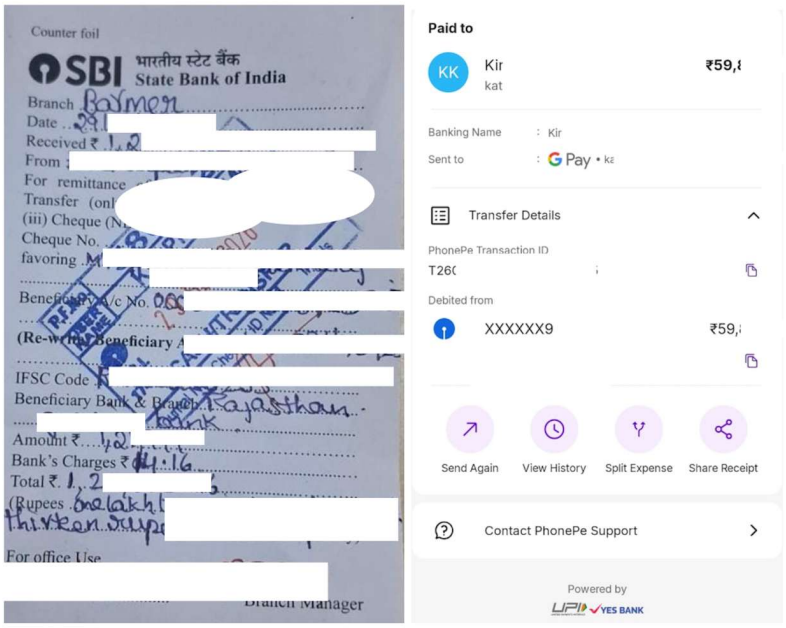


a phishing site spoofing Coinbase with fake crypto trading dashboards and custom Telegram "Customer Support"

- The fraud portal, the invite link **akygypeilj[.]my** used a redirect to second suspicious domain **ketqylwhlx[.]my** that impersonates Coinbase branding. Victims logged into a fake web app UI displaying live crypto ticker pairs (BTC, ETH, DOGE), while being directed to interact with a fraudulent Coinbase customer support profile on Telegram.

Phase 3: Instructing Victims to deposit to specific individual bank accounts

- Scammers instructed victim to send large sums to specific individual bank accounts at Indian rural regional bank accounts via over-the-counter cash deposit and PhonePe transfer to private individuals.
- The victim deposited around ₹1.2 lakh into a regional bank account, while the rest was transferred via various PhonePe/UPI transactions. Payment, sender, and receiver details have been redacted due to privacy concerns.

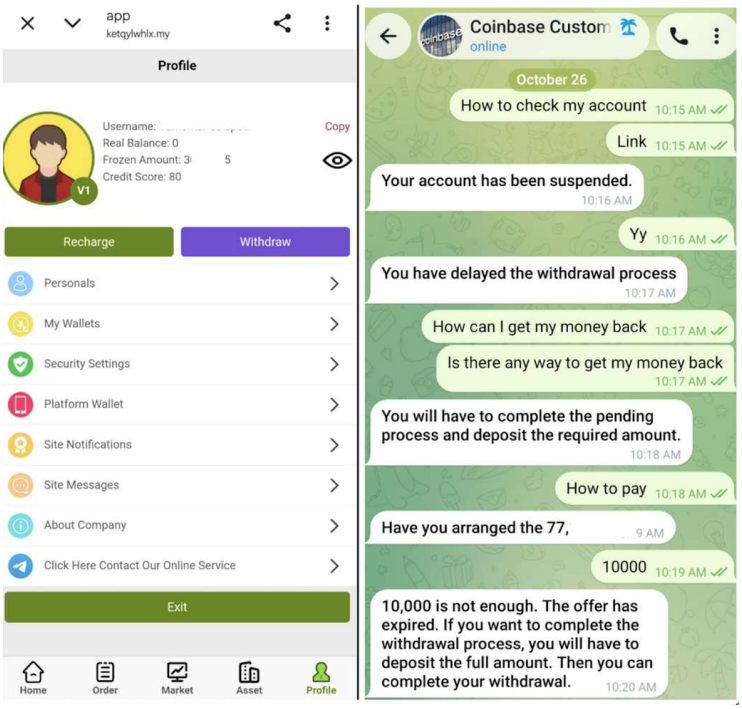


series of money transfered to scammer instructed bank accounts

- Criminal Syndicates recruit vulnerable individuals or acquire third-party savings accounts to layer and launder stolen funds.
- Criminals force victims to use physical cash deposits at bank branches or direct UPI transfers to bypass digital fraud monitoring systems, freeze orders, and corporate payment gateway checks.
- **[Red Flag 5]** Demanding exact, arbitrary figures and large transfers directed to unrelated third-party personal accounts rather than legitimate corporate escrow or merchant accounts.

Phase 4: The End: Extortion & Withdraw Access Lockdown

- Account Freezing: The scam dashboard shows a Real Balance of 0 and a Frozen Amount around ₹3 lakh rupees

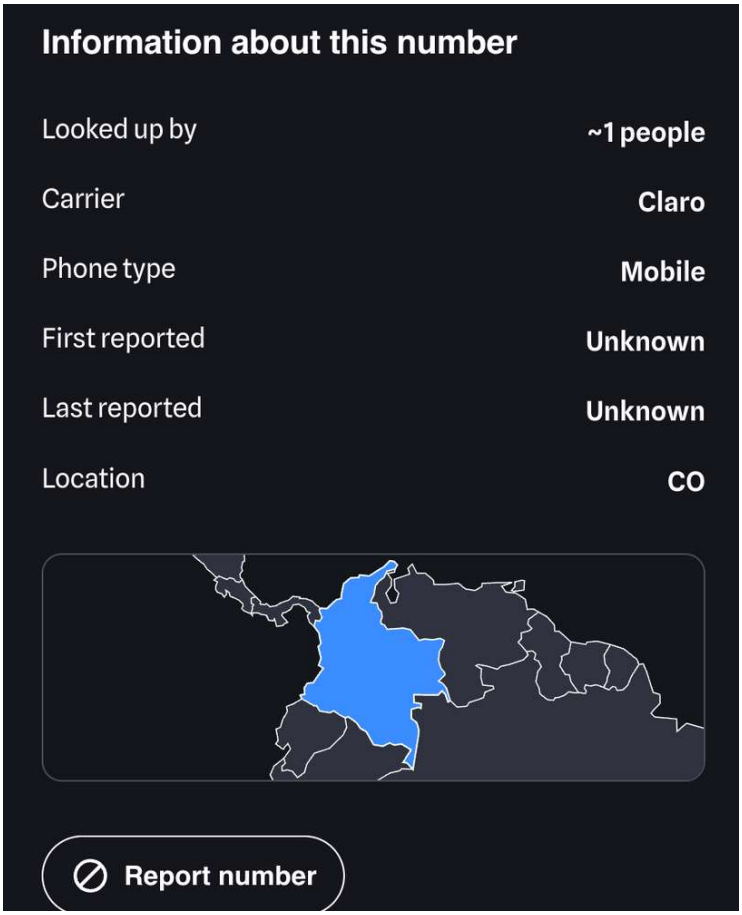


The scam reaches its final extortion phase, freezing and asking additional money.

- The fake Telegram support account (Coinbase Custom) informed the victim that his account is suspended for delaying the withdrawal process. To unfreeze the ₹3.08 Lakh, they demand an additional deposit of about ₹77,000.
- In reality, even if the victim pays the scammers will generate another fake tax, fee, or verification barrier to extract more money until the victim stops paying.
- **[Red Flag 6]** Displaying zero liquid balance, locking large sums withdrawal sums, and demanding capital deposits as a condition to release existing funds, Setting strict deadlines, declaring partial payments expired, refusing incremental payments.

3. OpenSource Intelligence (OSINT) Analysis - Infrastructure

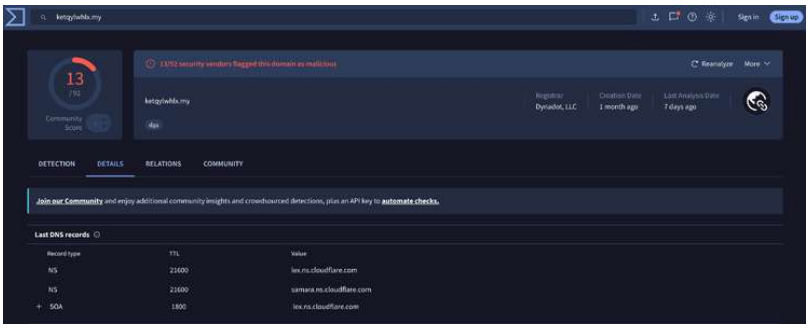
- **Mobile Number Lookup**: From Malwarebytes Mobile number reverse lookup, this number is active and belongs to carrier **Claro** from colombia



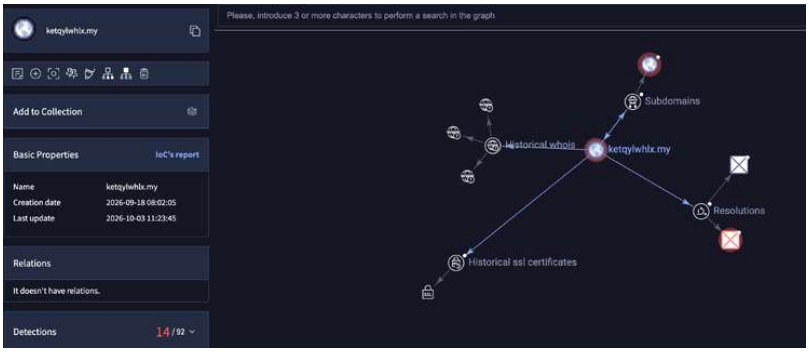
Mobile number reverse lookup

- **Domain and URL lookup : Virustotal**

- The domain was created on September 18, 2026, registered through Dynadot, LLC using redacted/anonymized registrant details. a **Let's Encrypt TLS certificate** valid through **December 17, 2026** covering both the root domain and a wildcard configuration (*.ketqylwhlx.my)



Domain lookup



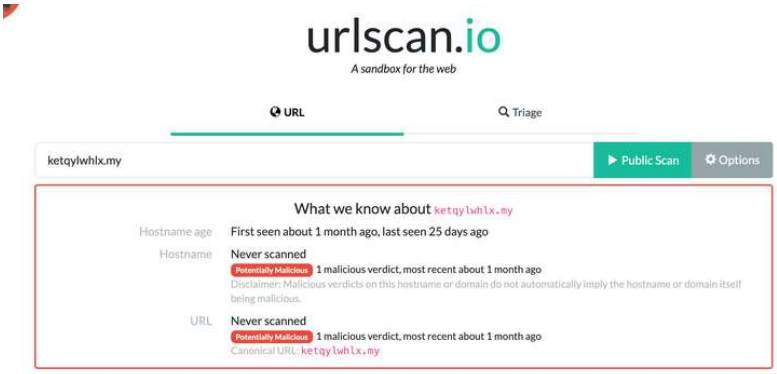
Suspicious domain relationship graph

- From an infrastructure perspective, the domain relies on **Cloudflare** for DNS management (lex.ns.cloudflare.com and samara.ns.cloudflare.com) and resolves exclusively to Cloudflare proxy IP addresses (104.21.57.215 and 172.67.167.10).

> This setup allows the scammers to hide the true origin IP of their hosting server behind Cloudflare's reverse-proxy network while benefiting from automated SSL generation

URLScan : To investigate suspicious Domains/URL

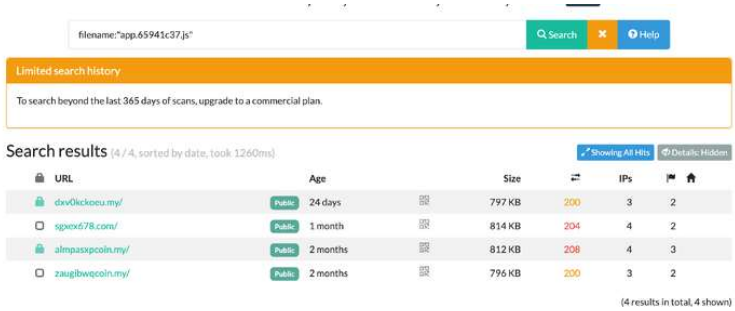
- urlscan.io highlighted that this domain is "Potentially Malicious"



urlscan suspicious domain lookup

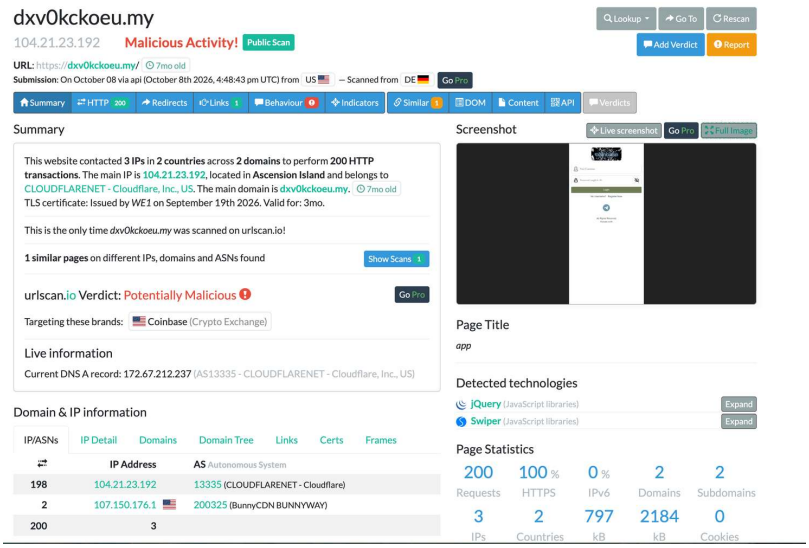
- Using the unique JavaScript bundle filenames, hashes and keyword signatures discovered during analysis, I expanded the scope to uncover related infrastructure.
- To search similar scam websites using file name app.65941c37[.]js (I obtained this name while conducting dynamic analysis)

```
filename:app.65941c37.js
```



suspicious crypto scamming domains

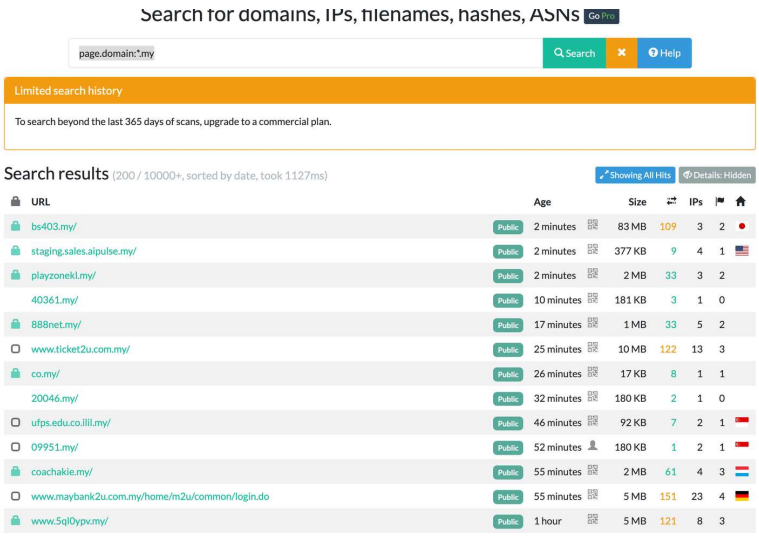
- dxv0kckoeu[.]my using same scamming kit



similar look like scamming website

- URLScan search to find domains with ".my" as TLD

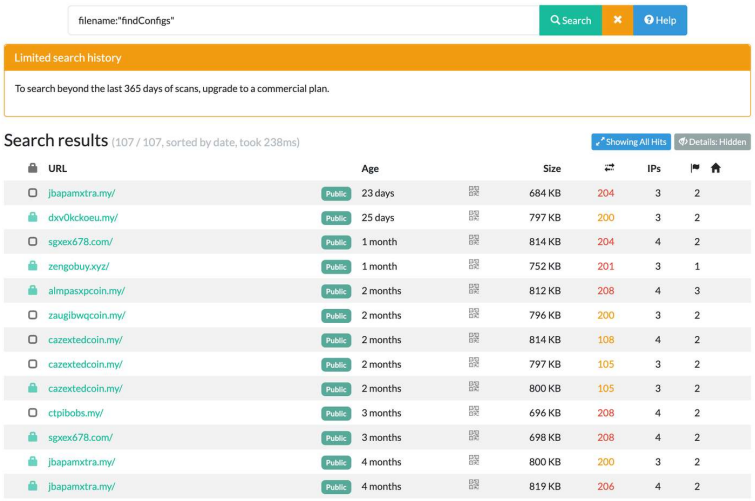
```
page.domain:*.my
```



.my TLD domains from urlscan search

- I was able to map 47 similar scamming domains (after removing the duplicate results from urlscan) using search keyword "findConfigs"

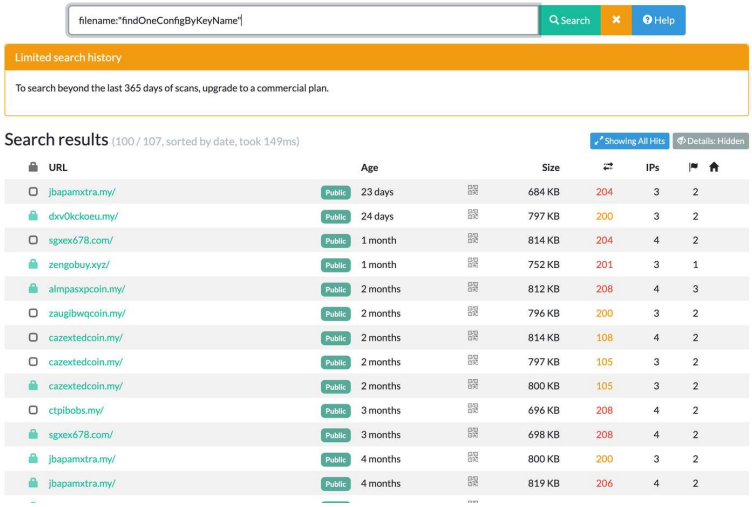
```
filename:"findConfigs"
```



suspicious crypto investment scam domains

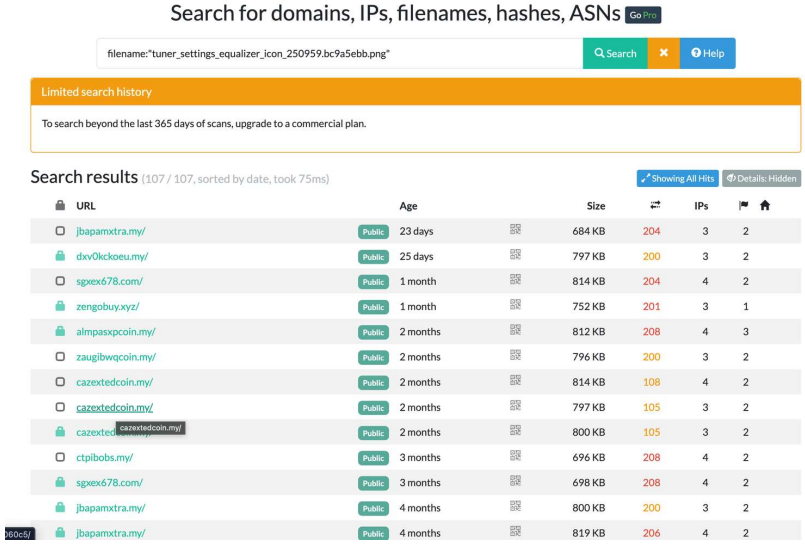
- filename keyword "findOneConfigByKeyName"

```
filename:"findOneConfigByKeyName"
```



suspicious crypto investment websites

```
filename:"tuner_settings_equalizer_icon_250959.bc9a5ebb.png"
```



suspicious scamming websites

4. Dynamic Analysis

- Any.run is a great tool to conduct dynamic and sandbox analysis, I was able to collect suspicious JS, Telegram contact (may be author of scamkit) details and few other IoC

> This suspicious investment scam app is invite only; scammers share invitation code via whatsapp chat.

- While conducting the dynamic analysis, I observed the suspicious trading app constantly polling victim personal information, application configuration, notices, home-page information, and market-price data from "Trading View"
- The response contains bank-wallet information, including bank name, account-holder name, bank-card number, and associated user identifiers. Another response contained user-profile information, including phone number, login name, registration details, last-login metadata, referral information, and fund-password configuration status.



collecting victim and bank details

Response also contains a JSON user record.

- user_id – internal user identifier.
- phone – registered phone number.
- login_name – account login name.
- real_name and nick_name – user identity/profile fields.
- status – account status.
- last_login_ip and last_login_time – previous login information.

- register_ip and register_time – registration information.
- invite_code – referral identifier.
- has_pay_password – indicates whether a fund/transaction password is configured.



collecting victim IP address details

- At the time of analysis, Any.run did not label this suspicious crypto scam website as malicious.



any.run labeled as "no threats detected"

5. Source Code/Suspicious JS files analysis

- The frontend appears to use a Vue.js and Webpack architecture, with Vue Router, Vuex, Axios, and a collection of independently bundled JavaScript components.
- The application supports separate login and fund passwords.
- It contains anti-debugging and browser-inspection countermeasures via the disableInfo() function. This code snippet contains several deliberate mechanisms designed to prevent users and security analysts from inspecting a web application. Specifically, **Developer Tools blocking, Right-click disabling, Debugger timing detection, DOM destruction, Obfuscated JavaScript property names and a Telegram contact message displayed when certain conditions are triggered.**



Anti-debugging and might be scam kit author Telegram details

- Anti-debugging mechanism : It measures how much time passes between two Date objects; If the difference exceeds 10 milliseconds,

it assumes that something has interrupted execution. One possible cause is a debugger breakpoint, When that happens, it clears the entire page body.

```
(function noDebuger() {
    function testDebuger() {
        var lCHds_1 = new window["\x44\x61\x74\x65"]();

        if (new window["\x44\x61\x74\x65"]() - lCHds_1 > 10) {
            window["\x64\x6f\x63\x75\x6d\x65\x6e\x74"]
                ['\x62\x6f\x64\x79']
                ['\x69\x6e\x6e\x65\x72\x48\x54\x4d\x4c'] = '';

            return true;
        }

        return false;
    }
})();
```

Suspicious JS code

- The login component specifically retrieves support configuration for telegram and whatsapp

```
this.axios.get(
    this.api.api_findConfigs,
    {
        params: {
            names: "telegram,whatsapp"
        }
    }
);
```

JS code from suspicious website

- DOM Destruction mechanism; replacing the application and removing the page resources

```
document.getElementById("app").innerHTML = `
<h1>
  白嫖可耻!开发 Telegram:@superthomas
</h1>`;

setTimeout(() => {
    document.querySelectorAll("script,link,style")
        .forEach(function(el) {
            el.remove();
        });
}, 800);
```

suspicious website with Telegram user details

- Browser resize detection: It records the initial browser dimensions. If the dimensions change, it attempts to close the window.

```
var initialHeight = window.innerHeight;
var initialWidth = window.innerWidth;

window.onresize = function() {
    if (
        initialHeight != window.innerHeight ||
        initialWidth != window.innerWidth
    ) {
        window.close();
    }
};
```

Browser window size detection

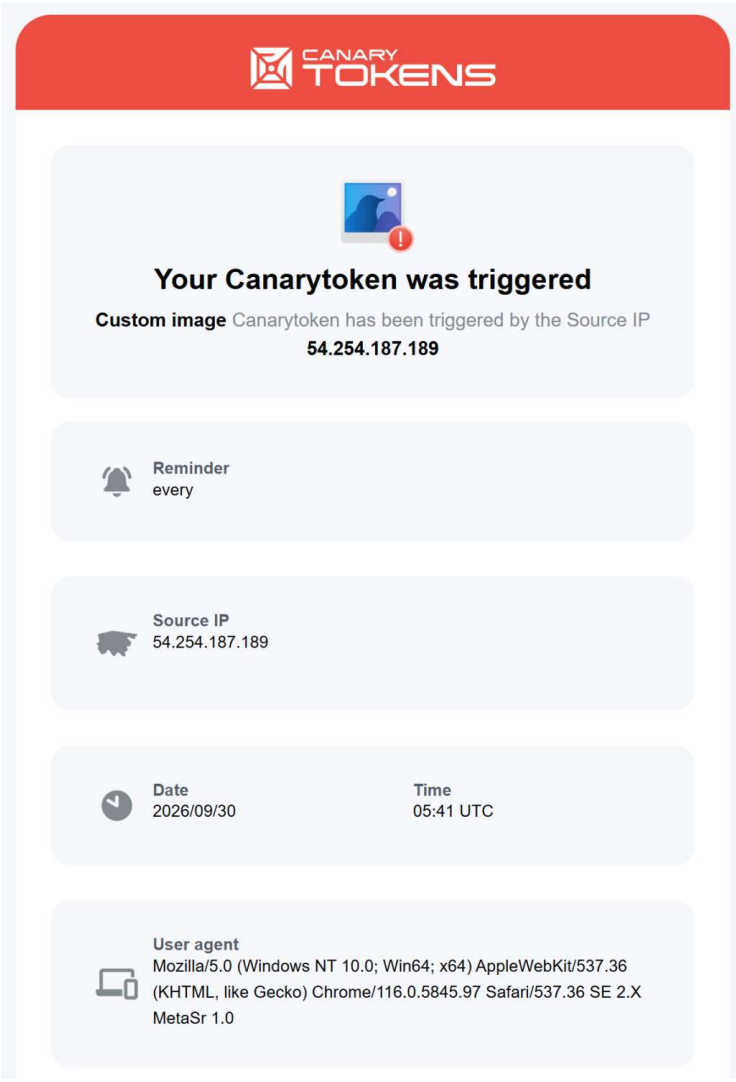
- The following are the corresponding API paths identified in the JavaScript source code.

Functionality	API endpoint
User registration	`/api/mine/userRegister`
User login	`/api/mine/userLogin`
User information	`/api/mine/getUserByUserId`
Password update	`/api/mine/updateUserPassword`
Wallet information	`/api/mine/getBankWallet`
Digital wallet	`/api/mine/getDigitalWallet`
Deposit	`/api/mine/recharge`
Withdrawal	`/api/mine/withdraw`
Transaction history	`/api/asset/findMoneyRecord`
Market prices	`/api/home/findNowPrice`
Trading orders	`/api/market/betOrder`
Order history	`/api/order/getOrder`
Chat	`/api/chat/modifyGroupNameOrNotice`

Observed API endpoints

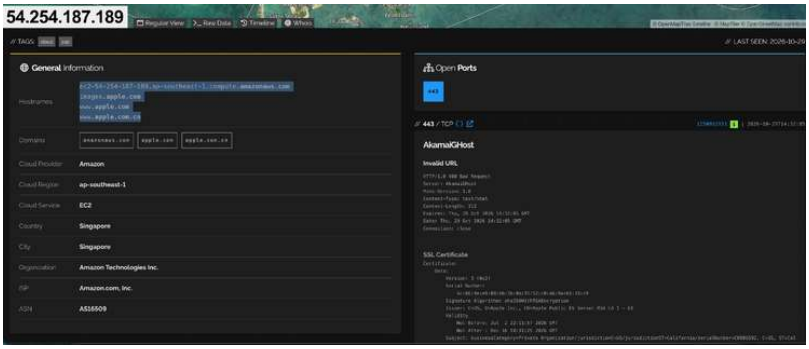
6. Threat Hunting: Fingerprinting the operator with Canary token

- I sent a canarytoken as web url with image, which was opened from operator-associated proxy infrastructure (54.254.187[.]189, AWS ap-southeast-1) by a Windows 64-bit client reporting Sogou Explorer 2.X (Chromium 116).



collected canary token response

- IP reverse lookup pointing to AWS EC2 instance hosted in Singapore



AWS EC2 lookup from Shodan

- Useragent

```
Mozilla/5.0 (Windows NT 10.0; Win64; x64)
AppleWebKit/537.36 (KHTML, like Gecko)
Chrome/116.0.5845.97 Safari/537.36 SE 2.X MetaSr 1.0
```

- **Most likely, this might be** a Windows desktop, laptop, or a Windows VPS/RDP box, AWS Singapore EC2 egress, which might be proxy hop. Sogou Explorer is almost exclusively installed by users in mainland China, so I suspect this "might" be a Chinese-speaking operator.

7. Conclusion

Scammers build trust with small payouts, then show fake profits to make you deposit more, and the money you send to a stranger's account is gone. No real job or investment will ever ask you to pay more to get your own money back. Stop, don't send money, and report it to authorities right away.

If you or someone you know is targeted, **Before you report,** save chat exports, screenshots with timestamps, receipts, and URLs. **Don't send more money, and don't pay anyone who offers to "recover" your funds for a fee.**

India

1. **Call 1930** (National Cyber Crime Helpline) immediately.
2. **File at** cybercrime.gov.in with transaction IDs, beneficiary bank/UPI details, screenshots, the domains, and the Telegram/WhatsApp handles.
3. **Tell your bank right away** and ask for a fraud dispute and beneficiary flagging.
4. Optionally file an FIR at the local cyber police station.

USA

1. **FBI IC3 (**ic3.gov**):** domains, handles, wallet addresses, timeline, loss amount.
2. **FTC (**reportfraud.ftc.gov**)** for consumer-fraud tracking.
3. **Your bank or card issuer**, and the crypto exchange if crypto was sent, so they can flag the destination.

As a community we can fight against these cyber crimes and scams, You don't need to be a victim or an analyst to make this harder for the scammers

- **Report the domain to Google Safe Browsing** (its phishing/malware report form) so browsers warn users.
- **Report to the registrar and the CDN.** The domain registrar (e.g., Dynadot) and Cloudflare both have abuse forms, and the country-code registry (MYNIC for .my) can suspend domains.
- **Forward scam numbers** to Whatsapp/Telegram scam/fraud reporting so the numbers can be investigated and blocked.
- **Share indicators** (defanged domains, file hashes, handles) with community trackers such as PhishTank, Chainabuse, and VirusTotal community comments. Don't post victim details or live links.
- **Report the impersonated brand.** If a scam uses a real company's name, such as an exchange, tell its abuse team.

- **Warn your family.** Share the red flags: foreign numbers claiming to be local recruiters, small "demo payouts," moves to Telegram, personal-account deposits, and "pay to unlock."

Note: This is an awareness article based on a real incident. All victim and third-party personal data has been removed or redacted. The scam domain shown is already offline and flagged by antivirus engines.

References

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3. https://app.any.run/tasks/dee02659-aca4-4994-ac7e-060df4ec7588/
4. https://canarytokens.com
5. https://urlscan.io/result/01a0f935-1d93-73c6-9b20-4e87347015cc/#summary
6. https://www.virustotal.com/graph/ketqylwhlx.my
7. https://theprint.in/india/cybercrime-saw-24-spike-in-2025-indians-lost-rs-22495-crore-mainly-in-investment-scams/2859930/
8. https://urlscan.io/result/01a199e4-a346-74a9-836c-d100fe974e5e/
9. https://www.virustotal.com/gui/domain/pockwebio.my/relations
10. https://urlscan.io/search/#filename:%22findOneConfigByKeyName%22
11. https://urlscan.io/search/#filename:%22tuner_settings_equalizer_icon_250959.bc9a5ebb.png%22
12. https://urlscan.io/result/01a19a9c-774c-75fa-a9d8-12de4613f8f1/
13. https://urlscan.io/responses/2ae8fafb88a70e8dab923dd9f691bb3bd5369700c670fa59b92fd580bd9541ca/
14. https://www.virustotal.com/gui/ip-address/104.21.57.215/relations
15. https://www.virustotal.com/gui/ip-address/172.67.167.10/details
16. https://www.virustotal.com/gui/ip-address/188.114.96.3/detection
17. https://www.virustotal.com/gui/domain/akygypeilj.my/details
18. https://urlscan.io/search/#filename%3Aapp.65941c37.js
19. https://urlscan.io/result/01a11c6a-ccc5-732a-9181-4f5ae1697294/
20. https://urlscan.io/search/#page.domain%3A*.my
21. https://urlscan.io/search/#filename:%22findConfigs%22
22. https://www.coinbase.com/en-it/blog/anatomy-of-a-telegram-scam
23. https://www.shodan.io/host/54.254.187.189

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